SANCTUM

POEMS

KEVIN BRADY McLEAN

SANCTUM

Poems

KEVIN BRADY McLEAN

© 2026 Kevin Brady McLean

All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced or distributed in any form or by any means without the prior written permission of the author, except for brief quotations used in reviews or other uses permitted by law.

First edition

In memory of

Laura Denise McLean
Jeffrey Adam McLean
Danielle McLean

and for

Cora Danielle McLean

I am the master of my fate:
I am the captain of my soul.

William Ernest Henley, *Invictus*

I didn't set out to make a book. These came one at a time, over years, and it was a long while before I noticed they were all working at the same few questions from different rooms.

Some reach for God and the old names. Others stay near what was taken, and what's still standing. I've put them in an order that felt right rather than the order they arrived, and I haven't tried to explain any of it. I'm not sure I could.

A few ask more of you than the rest. That wasn't a decision. They asked more of me first.

K.B.M.

Contents

Atlas 1
A Priori 2
B Is for Bombadil 3
Petrichora 5
Brood 6
Dire Wolf 7
Repentacle 8
Gate of the Union 9
Conflick 10
Innerdimensional 11
Scorpid 12
Saint Germain 13
Unique Collective Awareness 14
Rosegold 15
Beneath the Bodhi Tree 16
As I Stand Before Leviathan 18
Remonstrance 21
Chronovisor 23
Walter Russell 26
Physical Law 28
Mnemosyne 29
Braile 31
Golden Shadow 32
Soul Fracture 34
Pensacola Beach Bound 35
The Shell Pile 36
Sublemonal 37
Old No. 12 (The Final Song) 38
Ardor 39
The Butcher of New Liberty 40
Francis Drake Underwood 42
Black Market 43
The Meta-Sin 44
Rabid Obedience 45
Turnstile 47
Plain Sight Prince 48
Ikarious 49
Abraxis 50
Duart 51

Atlas

What are the things that we can say while we're still being honest?
I can't remember everything, but I know that I made you a promise.
Some stories are written in the stars, others only in the comets.
The truth exists, so save yourself some room to be astonished.

I know that flesh feels heavy, but your spirit can't be caged.
Not the wisdom of the wizard nor the force within the mage.
It is within your nature, that of the seer and the sage.
You'll find all the wonder in the turning of the page.

Relieve yourself of burdens for the things that were never yours,
But hold on to hope, for you will build yourself a door
To make way for those that follow and those who came before.
Keep your faith in your compass, not the number of the score.

I'll meet you in the shadows if you get lost within the plumb,
Remind you where you are going and just how far you've come.
Rejoice in war and peace, and welcome the sound of the battle drum.
When the victory is yours, you will remember where you're from.

A Priori

The child who's never touched the flame
already pulls her hand away
some ancient circuit speaks her name
in languages before the day.

I knew the depth before I drowned,
the way a sparrow knows the air,
how roots can feel their way through ground
toward water they've not tasted there.

The heart keeps time to rhythms old
as tides that move the sleeping sea,
a mathematics we were told
before we learned to count or see.

Your face was familiar when we met,
as if my blood had drawn the map
the body's long-remembered debt
to forms that fit like hand in lap.

Some knowledge lives inside the bone,
the way a seed contains the tree,
a theorem we have always known
but never proved empirically.

The mind unfolds what it contains:
these truths that need no teacher's hand,
like how the newborn infant strains
toward breast, toward warmth, toward motherland.

B Is for Bombadil

Joy without intention is motion unconfined,
Before the first phoneme could name or find,
There danced a being in the space between
The word for thing and what the thing might mean.

B is for Bombadil, but he came first,
Before the letter learned to slake its thirst
For meaning, mapping, making order known,
He was the chuckle that bounced off echoed stone.

The scholars say that naming carries the power,
That Adam's true gift was language as a tower
From which to see and sort and understand,
But he was there singing back when soil was sand.

He knows the secret that the vowels keep,
The reason consonants refuse to sleep:
That every symbol is a container, a kind of cage,
And freedom lives long before the written page.

B is for Beginning, but he's older, still,
B is for the Boundary, but bolder he feels
Than any line we draw to keep things clear,
He predates parallels and glass, he has no peer.

The corruption of power found in him no door,
For doors require a frame, a wall, a floor,
And Bombadil is what the frame forgot,
The is that simply is and answers it's not.

So when you learn your letters, bittersweet and young,
Remember some things danced before they sung,
That B might be for Being, bare and bright,
The good thing itself before we called it light.

The ancient intelligence is this:
That knowing is a kind of violence you miss
Turned into contract, wonder turned to sheer fact,
The bomb or the deal signals the final act.

There will he be, still, when the last book turns to dust,
When alphabets collapse back into rust,
Still singing in the syntax reduced to whisper, then forgot,
The grammar of the is, the was, and the not.

Petrichora

The air grows taut before the rain,
A scent lifts lightly from the ground,
It drifts like brightness without name,
And leaves a silence all around.

The earth exhales a quiet call,
A promise carried on frail air,
It touches places that recall
What is not present anywhere.

No storm arrives to break the spell,
The fragrance hovers, soft and brief,
It hints at something none can tell,
A coming light, a gentle grief.

The dust remembers what might be,
This breath before the clouds unfold,
It lingers, neither bound nor free,
An absence bright, and never old.

Brood

A cold wind blows, and the leaves slowly lift,
An invisible force dawning the holiest gift,
to clear out the fog and lift the veil,
raising the tide, and filling the sail.

The robin's brood chirps and spreads its wings,
diving into the change that the motion brings.
A trust fall into life, no respect for death,
as blue egg shells fall from the lampshade nest.

Mine eyes cast upon it through the windowed door,
peering the clumsy descent to the wooden floor.
Our stares intertwined, lacking all sense of fright,
as the birds hop around before taking their flight.

The last memory to hold is their shadows casted,
an unforgiving toll that nature's outlasted.
There is healing within as they answer the call,
because all things still grow beyond the wall.

Dire Wolf

Beneath the pine and breaking dawn;
upon the yew, sinew string is drawn.
The mark is neither friend nor foe,
as one eye tracks the yearling doe.

Fearless the archer, but for the howl
of the wolf or the bare stomach growl.
It is the latter that calls for sacrifice,
and what would prosper now pays the price.

With no wind fall, and the forest still;
soaring cedar carries the hunger's will.
No points to count, there's only a cost;
no trophy hangs for things that are lost.

A midsummer morning now has need for fire;
an unfortunate act becomes what is admired.
Smoke fills the air as what burns turns to coal,
what's fulfilled the flesh has emptied the soul.

Repentacle

In the beginning was the great forgetting's art,
And this forgetting served the greater good,
For how else could divinity know surprise?
How else could sleeping dreamers wake to truth understood?

The pentacle turns circles, wheel in wheel sublime,
Each rotation peels away another veil,
Until the inner sanctum opens wide and clear,
Empty, infinite, the home beyond the pale.

To repent is cosmic turning, always so,
The planets understand this orbital law,
The seasons and the tides and breath know well,
That turning, always turning, is the only flaw.

The caduceus rises through the spine like flame,
Two serpents asking questions without shame:
What if you were never broken from the start?
What if wholeness always sought its counterpart?

In chambers where salt dissolves in mercury's embrace,
The base metal remembers its noble grace,
The stone recalls it was philosopher from birth,
Understanding its primordial worth.

And you stand at the threshold between the worlds tonight,
Neither mortal flesh nor pure celestial light,
Discovering becoming was returning all along,
The pentacle forever pointing home where you belong.

Gate of the Union

Two pillars hold the open air,
No lock, no hinge, no bar,
The threshold stands to make you swear
You were not whole before.

One foot in grief, one foot in gold,
The body splits in two,
But stepping through, you learn what's old:
Division never true.

The gate holds nothing back from you,
It guards no sacred ground,
It simply shows what always knew
Itself as lost and found.

Here enemy and friend collapse,
Here self and other fade,
The gate reveals the ancient maps
Were drawn on light, not shade.

Not entrance, exit, wall, or door,
But recognition's arch,
Where all that you were warring for
Surrenders to the march.

The union is not made but seen,
Not forged but understood,
The gate stands at the space between
What is and always stood.

So when you reach the pillared way,
Don't ask what lies beyond,
The gate itself has this to say:
You never were alone. Welcome home.

Conflick

Some find theirs at the crossroads with Baron Samedi,
others somewhere in the lines of a peaceful treaty.
I found my enlightenment where souls distill,
the point where God's Plan crosses Free Will.

Now abandoned the cauldron, for fearful the witch
of the lines of the salt surrounding their spiritual ditch.
They are conveyed about in a bottle, a comfortable hearse,
reflecting energetic waste from the bottom of the universe.

Lacking the grip to take lives with strangulation,
so far harder they try with triangulation,
binding in darkness and claiming the night is true,
while cursing at the light that is shining through.

Spitefully, sodium only holds what agrees to be held,
and a curse is a letter freely written unto itself.
There is neither jar nor thread where souls distill,
only a violet flame burning, the plan finding the will.

Innerdimensional

Astonishing what the planets do;
for pattern recognition, isn't it?
Let the holy fire rise,
alight!
Set ablaze all that remains.
Saturn. Reignition.

Jupiter cracks the vault,
gold light floods the ribs.
The old guard falls quiet.
No throne left to defend.
Awake.
The kingdom was breath.

Mars burns the shell away,
red flakes drift like ash.
Every wound opens wide.
Blood remembers home.
Strike once.
The fight dissolves.

Venus softens the gaze,
mirror holds no blame.
Skin wakes to its own warmth.
Beauty never left.
Return.
Here was always enough.

Mercury quiets the chatter,
words sink into still water.
Mind folds to one point.
No more chasing.
Listen.
This is the whole thing.

Scorpid

Summer lurks over the southern horizon
I wish you would rise a little higher
So I could see Antares burn
With your heart of fire.

An agent of the huntress Artemis
On her mission to dispatch Orion
Hearing of his unrepentant pride
As if he could slay the Lion.

As reward, Zeus placed you in our sky
Forever immortalizing your sting
The hunter meanwhile remains on the fly
Fading into the sunrise each spring.

Forever, this celestial pursuit
Through the heavens, endless dispute.

Saint Germain

In chambers dim where monarchs schemed,
A shadow lingers, veiled in grace,
His form a thread through history's seam,
Eternal watch on time's slow pace.

He tends the violet flame concealed,
That subtle fire of change unknown,
Transmuting eras' wounds unhealed
To quiet gold, where ash was sown.

No crown he claims, no scepter bright,
But custodianship through vein and bone,
A covenant whispered into night,
Passed hand to hand, from stone to stone.

Through Versailles' gleam and Bastille's roar,
He glides, a murmur in the fray,
Steering the tide from shore to shore,
Yet leaving no imprint on the clay.

In hidden vaults where secrets bind,
He forges continuity's chain,
Not seizing thrones, but minds refined,
Preserving light through storm and rain.

For he has walked the futures past,
And seen the cycles bend and break,
A steward sworn to hold them fast,
Till dawn renews what night would take.

Unique Collective Awareness

It is innate to us all, the ability to leverage transmutation,
to turn the darkness into the light for our own transformation.
But there is patience required, patience and dedication,
when it is in your intention to birth a brand new nation.

If energy follows the path of least resistance
then why do we fight with such undue persistence?
Take for granted its presence but when it's gone we miss it;
then battle the silence that echoes and carries relentless.

May the strength that it takes be found to roll your dice,
even when these cubes are loaded with lead and poltergeists.
Under the crescent moon as the lunacy folds the night,
while the tips of your fingers reach for what's out of sight.

Rosegold

Until you first choose to be heart-led
the blind will be led by the blind.
Stead by the poets, whom art-fed,
see Truth in the framework behind

the brittle scaffolding of fact,
where numbers and decrees grow cold.
They trace the hidden, living tract
that pulses beneath crowns of gold.

For reason alone builds towers tall,
yet windowless and sealed from light;
the heart, though wild, can breach the wall
and flood the dark with second sight.

So turn from maps of silicon and ink,
from grids that chart the world in lines
where every star is pinned in sync
and wonder ever, lowly dies.

Let feeling be your compass rose,
its needle trembling toward the vast;
the poets walk where logic fears
and find the future amongst the past.

For only love can read the script
etched faint upon the unseen air,
the heart leads best when its fires are lit,
and truth is breathed, not reasoned there.

Beneath the Bodhi Tree

He did not conquer on that night,
whatever statues say.
The war was waged inside the light
and would not go away,
and every army Mara raised
came marching straight for me,
for him, for anyone who stays
beneath the Bodhi tree.

The soldiers came with iron first,
the daughters came with fire,
and last arrived the question cursed
to cut through all desire:
Just who do you believe you are?
It echoes endlessly.
He pressed his hand into the char
beneath the Bodhi tree.

No scripture read, no sermon said,
no counsel at his side.
He called the earth to stand instead
and let the ground decide.
A man with nothing left to prove
submits his final plea
by touching what refused to move
beneath the Bodhi tree.

I've sat below my lesser wood,
a live oak gone to ghost,
a courthouse pine that overstood
with sight from coast to coast.
No empires came with bargained plan,
no thrones were offered free,
just whispers saying fold your hand
beneath a lesser tree.

Give up, they said, and call it fate,
agree you'd always lose.
The ruin came collecting late
in quiet, patient dues.
But I reached down through fertile sand
the Gulf gave back to me,
and let it testify firsthand
to what the tide had raised in me.

I will not call it lightning struck
or heaven splitting wide.
Tell you the armies ran out of luck.
Whisper the daughters stepped aside.
Say a man sat still so long,
so far past the will to flee,
the morning took him for the strong
unmoving Bodhi tree.

It gave him what it gives the stone,
the root, the patient sea,
the same light every dawn has thrown
on all that will not be
unseated, shaken, bought, or bent,
on all that stays to see
the siege dissolve the way it went,
beneath the Bodhi tree.

As I Stand Before Leviathan

I came with names etched deep in bone,
Carved from scrolls and shadowed stone,
Believing knowledge held the throne
Where will and world might yet entwine.
The sea before me lay in wait,
A mirror flat, without a gate,
And I, presuming to translate
Its depths to measures of my line.

From distant shores I bore the weight
Of covenants, of oaths innate,
The moral arc I deemed my fate,
A clarity that pierced the brine.
Yet as I stood, the waters stirred,
Not by my call, nor spoken word,
But by a presence long deferred,
Rising slow from the unconfined.

Leviathan, whose form defies
The fragile frames of mortal eyes,
Uncoils from abyssal lies
Where pressure forges bone from night.
No beast of myth, no scripted foe,
But principle that ebbs and flows,
The limit woven into woe,
The sovereign depth that claims its right.

Its scales, like continents adrift,
Bear currents ancient, cold, and swift,
Where time dissolves in salt's harsh gift,
And darkness presses without light.
I spoke the names, the sacred lore,
From Job's lament to ocean's core,
Expecting echo, nothing more,
A dialogue to bend the tide.

But silence met my uttered claim,
No thunder roared, no judgment came,
Only the swell that bore no name,
Rearranging waves in quiet pride.
The air grew thick with unseen force,
My breath compressed, my pulse divorced
From rhythms I had held by course,
As if the deep had claimed my side.

What sovereignty could I profess
Against this vast, unyielding press?
My will, a fleeting, fragile guess
Amid the continuity of sea.
For Leviathan regards no plea,
No bargain struck on bended knee,
But holds the covenant of decree,
Where creation's bounds are drawn decree.

In stillness then, it turned its gaze,
Not eyes of fire, but endless haze,
A movement vast that parts the ways
Of knowing from the named decree.
The waters parted, revealing bone
Of whales long sunk, of empires gone,
A rearrangement, stark and lone,
Of history's fragments, set for me.

Fear rose, not sharp, but slow and wide,
A humility that could not hide
Behind the veils of human pride,
Nor control what depths decree.
For what is will against the flow
That carves the canyons far below,
Where pressure shapes what none can know,
And limits bind eternity?

Questions lingered in the spray,
Unanswered in the light of day:
Can naming tame what will not stay,
Or knowing grasp what shifts decree?
Leviathan, in sovereign grace,
Withheld its voice, its hidden face,
Communicating through the space
Where silence weighs more heavily.

And as I stood, stripped bare of guise,
My knowledge dimmed before those eyes,
Identity dissolved in sighs
Of breath that matched the ocean's heave.
No triumph claimed, no ruin wrought,
But reckoning in what was taught:
The scale of self, so dearly bought,
Now clarified in what I leave.

Smaller now, yet etched with trace
Of depths that grant no second place,
I turn from that eternal space,
Bearing knowledge words cannot weave.
The sea resumes its soundless reign,
Leviathan descends again,
And I, in quiet, bear the strain
Of truths that only silence cleave.

Remonstrance

To that which set this vessel into motion,
which poured itself through blood and bone and breath,
which authored every fathom of this ocean
and signed in full the covenant with death:

I, being of the mind that was your making,
and of the body given to its weight,
do hereby file this formal undertaking
and lay my grievances before the gate.

It is recorded that you knew the measure
of what this life would ask before it asked.
That every cost was counted, every pressure
was factored in before the die was cast.

I do not come in anger, nor in error,
nor to undo the terms to which I'm bound.
I come because the hour makes it clearer
that something has been lost and must be found.

The loneliness, I grant, was in the charter.
The hunger and the silence, these I knew.
But I was not informed I'd be a martyr
to patience, to a daughter I can't view,

to a name made strange by those who held the ledger,
to a mother taken early from the page,
to walking every tightrope, every edge, a
solitary act across a windswept stage.

I put it to the court that this exceeds
the standard terms of suffering and trial,
that what was promised unto those who bleed
with purpose was at minimum a sign, once in a while.

I note the comet. I have noted many.
I note the door that opened when I knocked.
I am not without evidence. Not any
man who had your ear was ever mocked.

And yet I stand, diminished in the square of market,
invisible to those who hold the deed,
my work filed under no particular bracket,
my name unknown to those I'm meant to lead.

I therefore move, with all appropriate reverence,
and full acknowledgment of what you are,
that you remind this instrument, your servant,
of the distance that remains, and where we are.

That you illuminate the purpose of the waiting,
confirm the course, or amend the given plan.
I am not here to question your creating.
I am here because you know I understand

that you and I are not so far divided
as the gap between this prayer and its reply.
That what is being built was pre-decided
and what looks like a wall is only sky

compressed to temporary opacity,
a season in the testing of a frame.
I know this. And I hold it with tenacity.
I move for confirmation, all the same.

Respectfully submitted, under duress,
with gratitude for everything accrued.
I trust the silence. I will nonetheless
continue to be formally reviewed.

Chronovisor

They built a machine to look backward through time,
a Vatican project, a bell and a chime,
a lens ground from something they wouldn't define,
that bent what was visible past the design.

The priests saw the crucifixion, they claimed.
They saw Troy in its burning, they saw what was named
before naming existed, before the first frame
of the universe loaded and gave itself aim.

And then they shut it down.
Locked it, lost the schematic, burned the town
of every document that wore the crown
of proof, and let the silence settle down.

Because what do you do when the instrument shows
not just what was, but what nobody knows
is coming: the pattern, the root, the repose
of a future that rhymes with wherever this goes?

You close it.
You close it and hope nobody else
has figured out the frequency,
the resonant shelf
where time folds back on time like a looping of self
and the viewer becomes the viewed, the stealth

becomes the signal.
Becomes the thing seen.
The eye in the machine finds the eye in between
the moments, the gap where the light turns to green
and everything hidden steps into the scene.

See, the chronovisor was never a tool.
It was a mirror that followed a rule
the builders forgot in their need to be cool
with the cosmos: the seer is part of the pool.

You look through the lens and the lens looks back.
You trace the old light on its narrowing track
and somewhere in the noise, in the layering stack,
your own face appears in the temporal black.

And that's when you understand what they feared.
Not the past. Not the faces of those who appeared
in the bell's open eye before history cleared.
Not even the future, however it's veered.

What they feared was the now.
The eternal, unblinking, relentless somehow
of a present that shows you the what and the how
simultaneously, no before and no vow

of distance between you and every event
that ever compressed itself, came and went,
and left in the fabric its permanent dent,
its signature light, its original sent-

ness, its source.
The machine didn't travel.
It held the right course
to show that the traveler, unwound at the force
of attention, was always already the source.

The Vatican closed it.
The record went dark.
But somewhere the frequency holds its remark
in the bone of whoever was born with the mark
of seeing, which isn't a gift, it's a spark

that burns what it touches
and lights what remains
and leaves the one carrying it with the stains
of every dimension that crosses its lanes
and calls it by name in its own refrain.

The chronovisor wasn't a window.
It was a door.
And the ones who walked through it
don't need it anymore.

Walter Russell

What of a man? To draw the light before he found its name,
A cosmic blueprint burning eternally in his frame,
While others measured atoms, playing it safe and small,
The universe fell out of his lead; from the rise, to the fall.

From marble blocks he carved what imagination could see,
The very form of thought and the same of energy.
His chisel spoke in frequencies ringing divine,
Converting space to art, and chaos to ordered line.

They called him mad! Him! The prophet of the wave,
Who said that death was just what matter gave
To consciousness that never learned to die,
Knighting us spiral dancers in an endless sky.

He saw no shine in the sun, for its violence radiates,
That it is the stillness that holds the power that creates,
For every atom is little more than a thought compressed,
And love's the force that puts the void to rest.

At ninety-three sharper, still, than polished glass,
He told the scholars all their truths would truly pass.
That light and dark is, at no point, separate at all,
But lovers gracefully stepping at creation's ball.

Painting instrumental symphonies, writing music's laws,
Raised monuments to being, without refrain or pause,
A Renaissance soul delivered into an electric age,
Left the remnants of his cosmic origins dripping from canvas page.

They sleep on genius until the genius is gone,
But truth outlives the tomb it's written on,
He knew that all we seek can be found only in all we are,
It is the same void within us, is the same between each star.

Save your light and holy water, warrantless to the prophet in the dark
For they see the fire some miles, or years, before they see the spark,
Who live like lightning strikes anchored unto human skin,
The architects of where we are and where we've never been.

He left us maps to territories as newfound as they are vast:
The present's just a pleasant interruption to the past
And for every future ending is yet another door
These waves of our will touch infinity, without descent, as we lament
upon the shore.

Physical Law

Originally, all I wanted was my energy back.
Now I want yours, the slow heat left against the door
where your hand rested once, then fell away,
the wood still faintly warm, though you are no more.

I thought the body would forget its debt,
the borrowed light it gave and never claimed,
but every threshold holds the shape you set,
a pressure faint, yet never quite the same.

The rooms have learned to carry what you spent
without return, the quiet after-breath
that lingers in the grain of every vent,
a current neither living nor of death.

I do not knock. The silence keeps its place.
The meter turns. The shadows lengthen slow.
What you released becomes the thing I trace,
not to restore, but simply to know.

The door stands closed. The warmth has not yet fled.
I wait for what was given, never said.

Mnemosyne

She holds what you buried when beauty grew bearable,
the want you dissolved into something more wearable,
the wound that healed into a wall,
a wall into a nation, standing tall
and you inside it unrepairable.

Name its borders "landscape" and call it "peace"
demanding of your longing its release,
perform the auditions and lose the thread
and love the self you put to bed
the one who made the aching somehow cease.

A slow cessation like a softening of days,
a light shone faint through amber haze,
and still the morning glass remembers you,
your name misting the cold to something true
a seeing beyond this endless maze.

She calibrates and sets the clock back through regret
to where you stood so purely in your debt
to longing, where the longing was indeed
the hour the careful architect of need
dismantled what remembrance can't forget.

Forget the hand and that room full of open vow
the Tuesday beauty no one would allow
go back and find that thread, retrieve the grain
of who you were before objections abstained
practicality became your here and now.

Before that word was spoken cold and uttered clean
and something in you nodded to convene
with compromise, called the dying growth,
kept walking, disciplined, and shed the oath
of everything you were at seventeen.

At seventeen the temple was sacred fire
the north rang full of consequence in choir
she holds it all in amber, dead and true
the precise and unrelenting residue
of everything you gave to desire.

Beyond the searching and before the gate
in the breath before you whispered you were late
go down to where the first things always dwell,
carry nothing save the thing you fell
into the once you learned to wait.

Braile

I'll be the first to admit there are things that I still don't understand,
and, to tell the truth, I'm seeing some proof that, perhaps, I never will.
I'm not sure where it is that I'm going; this is not something planned,
but I hope that whenever I find that future version of me, he's fighting
the devil still.

Yesterday keeps calling, but it's come the time that I stop picking up the
phone;
tell my secretary to return the call and inform the other party that I'm
never coming home.

Golden Shadow

Beneath the skin, where old griefs lie unburied,
I carry the gift that turns what I touch to gold.
Not the bright metal kings once craved, but something colder:
the way pain, once named, hardens into truth.

I reach into the dark rooms of the heart,
fingers brushing shame that has waited years
to be seen. It stiffens at my touch,
no longer soft rot, but solid, gleaming,
a relic I can hold without flinching.

What was poison becomes the weight I bear
with steady hands, the shadow no longer fleeing
but rising, clarified, to meet the light.
Every wound I dare to meet turns precious,
not because it shines, but because it no longer
bleeds unseen.

The light work follows, patient as dawn
after long night. I touch the places
where joy was buried alive,
and they too change, grow luminous,
not by force, but by recognition:
the small, forgotten tendernesses
hardened into something enduring.

Yet the gift is double-edged.
To turn the hidden into gold
is to lose its first wild softness,
the fragile pulse that once
could still surprise me.

I walk now through the rooms
I used to fear, hands open,
knowing whatever I meet will alter,
will become more itself
in the quiet fire of being seen.

And still I wonder, as the light
lengthens across the floor,
whether this alchemy
will leave me rich
or simply awake,
holding what remains
in palms that no longer tremble.

Soul Fracture

The radiologist holds an x-ray graph up to the light and says *nothing's broken* but we both know he's only looking at bone.

A therapist would probably name it a pattern. I call it a house I keep returning to even though I know where they hid the knife.

There is a word in Portuguese for the ache of something absent. I have been using it in the wrong language my whole life like carom.

The clock in my chest runs on a different meridian. Everyone here is having Tuesday. I am still somewhere in the middle of a year with too many digits.

My father taught me silence the way a river teaches stone… with the steady fact of itself, and time. Speak often, say little.

I have been kind to strangers in ways I have never managed with anyone I didn't know wouldn't stay.

In anatomy, I learned the heart is just a muscle. The poet says it is a fist that never learned to open. I say it is a room where the furniture keeps changing while the walls stay the same.

There is cartography in the fracture. You can date it, name it. You can put it on the record or trace the hairline back to its origin event. What you cannot do is decide when it stops being wound and starts being just the shape of you. Good luck trying to stop it.

They do not shatter clean. The soul fractures the way old porcelain does… still holding its form, still useful at the table, just threaded now with lines that show exactly where the cold got in between and forced it apart.

Pensacola Beach Bound

The sand remembers nothing
of the feet that press it daily,
yet cradles noon's fierce heat
long after the sun has drifted away.

Quartz grains gleam like scattered salt,
nearly blinding, nearly bright as bone,
a frozen drift of winter light
held fast against the Gulf's green moan.

Waves fold in without haste or claim,
each crest erasing what came before,
a patient rite of coming near
then drawing back to come once more.

Sea oats lean along the dunes' low spine,
tall stems swaying in soft accord
with every breath the wind designs,
roots threading deep through shifting hoard.

At the pier's long, weathered end
a man casts line into the same wide blue
that has received his offering
a thousand times, and answered true.

When the sun sinks to the water's shoulder,
the sky clings longer than it ought,
reluctant to release the shore
that has listened well to every thought.

The tide turns over, slow and sure.
No verdict falls, no promise spoken.
Tomorrow the sand will smooth itself again,
forget its own shape in the quiet dark,
and wait once more for light to mark
what form it chooses to awaken.

The Shell Pile

The shell pile rises, white and still,
beside the Blackwater's tea-dark flow,
a quiet hill of ancient will
where once the hungry gathered slow.

Oyster upon oyster lay,
cracked open by forgotten hands,
then left to mark the passing day
in ridges on the river's sands.

No plaque records the lives that fed
upon these gifts the water gave,
only the pile, unbowed, unbled,
holds witness where the current glides.

Cypress knees lift from shadowed stream,
like sentinels of patient time,
their roots drink deep the river's dream,
their silence speaks in measured rhyme.

The water moves without a sound,
carries the years, returns no name,
yet here the shells endure, profound,
a monument to daily claim.

Fishermen launch their boats once more,
cast lines into the same dark vein,
the pile remains, unchanged before,
while time dissolves the rest in vain.

The river bends, the light grows thin,
the shells keep watch through dusk and dawn.
What hands began, the years have been
too slow to carry, too patient gone.

Sublemonal

I was dead, now, I'm not
I believe in miracles
Laughter is close to insanity
Life's sort of hysterical

Death is just an idea
One I can't subscribe to
The reaper has an inner child
Just like you and I do

He's the only one I lie to
When we conversate
Say things he sees right through
When we conglomerate

Luckily
Unlike time, he can be forgiving
In the mornings we share coffee,
Write rhymes, I guess reliving

I try to work with him
He reminds me he's the boss
That he appreciates my words
That he's sorry for my loss

Tells me I'm a man of God
And he's only one of science
Together, both creators
An unholy alliance

He says it will be clean
When it's time to pay my toll
And when the bell rings
He'll be grateful for my soul

Old No. 12 (The Final Song)

They made their rest where quiet grass held fast,
No tremor stirred their feathers in the sun.
The time had come, only to pass,
And nothing more could alter what was done.
A single voice remained, a thread left to run.
The warder had heard what came before,
A lone sonata shaped by every score.

Each vanished song had carved a space to fill,
Some deep with fire, some measured with command.
Each left a trace in its final will,
A shaping only it could understand.
No note was lost, no meaning left unmanned.
The song arose, resolved, complete, and clear,
A single chord struck as all others veered.

It need not cry foul, nor falter, nor complain,
While holding the weight of all that had been sung.
The passing of their time left no stain,
Through this tone the world's true form was wrung.
No loss remained; no mortal grief was hung.
The final sound endured, unclaimed, alone,
A crown of silence made from each, their own.

Ardor

The only time you should vacate your throne is while you're standing
up for something you believe in
the rest is ceremonial; cold marble, and the long deceiving.
A crown is just the weight of what you haven't done yet,
a promise to yourself the mirror helps you to forget.

I've watched men grip their armrests through a flood,
calling the water holy when the drought is in their blood.
But sovereignty is motion in the very marrow of the bone,
you cannot rule the living from a perfectly kept throne.

The learned, lordly oak drops its acorns into mud,
surrenders its own empire to the seasons and the flood,
and still commands the hillside as both the tallest and the first
because it gave itself to rain before it ever gave to thirst.

So rise. And in the rising feel that old wood lose its pull.
The seat will hold your shape awhile, may the room remain half-full
of whoever you were sitting there,
that careful, measured, titled man who mistook stillness for despair.

What you believe in has an address. It is standing out in the cold.
You won't find it in the charter for it is neither written nor is it sold.
It's the thing that makes your heart move before your mind says go,
and the altar you keep returning to regardless of the snow.

Vacate your throne for that and when you sit again,
you'll begin to reign.

The Butcher of New Liberty

They gave him a boulevard, a handkerchief, and a bronze relief,
a ribbon-cut podium, an olive branch, and holly leaf.
Then called him the surgeon of the body politic,
the cure for the fever and the man with the trick.

He smiled like a statue of himself in advance,
shook the right hands in a well-rehearsed dance.
The crowd threw their confetti as if they allowed him a debt,
never asking what exactly they were paying for yet.

His apron was spotless when he stepped to the cutting block,
his calendar clean, his credentials, like cleavers, in board and stock.
But the butcher never advertises the cuts on the floor,
just the bloodied window display and the bell on the door.

He carved up the commons in a cold sterile light,
redistributed nothing but the language of the night.
Took the marrow from the middle, sold the fat to the few,
told the table it was progress, told the bones something new.

New Liberty! New Liberty! Though the banner says "Free!"
There's a sign in the back that says admission has a fee.
The fee is your future and your forefather's deed,
the slow-accrued trust that you planted like seed.

He renamed every wound so it felt like a gift,
called the divide a feature, whole, and the fall a "lift."
Had economists confirm it in a twelve-page decree,
had the choir sing the footnotes on prime-time TV.

The historians arrived with their tenure-worn pens,
drew a halo on the hammer as the abattoir transcends.
All the stains on the floor have a half-life, don't you know?
While the blood in the register never lies, it only grows.

New Liberty! New Liberty! Let the record show the monument stands!
Bronze hands extended with a bronze smile and bronze plans.
The pigeons and the geese have blessed him the way that foul will do
to anything tall that dare believes its own view.

He will carve himself up a legacy from what he has consumed,
call it a vision, or sacrifice, whatever it is; it blooms.
The Butcher of New Liberty will always know what he did,
in the quiet of the abattoir, and heart, he knows what he hid!

While the apron still hangs, clean, on the hook by the door...
the bell no longer rings for there's nothing left in store.

Francis Drake Underwood

The glint of steel reflects and blinds the eye,
boatswain draws blade, severs the anchor's tie.
Wide and tall, the cloth drops across the mast,
triskelion sails spring forth and shadows cast.

From crow's nest, a ragged Jolly Roger's spied,
and at the helm, rudders turn against the tide.
Below deck all gunners sing, as they hold fast,
they fear not the locker, nor the cannon blast.

The Atlantic horizon holds not a place to hide,
across piratical bow, hot spherical iron flies.
Black patchwork whip skyward as it speeds past,
torch and brazier ignite as a darkness amassed.

"You shall be boarded or sunk!" our master cried,
it is without their honor that the pirate dies.
Flintlock fire returned, our munitions outlast,
enemy plank further splintered pass after pass.

A white flag now raises where black once rides,
the captain surrenders and his mates all abide.
Bloodied deck leaks with the battle's contrast,
ship's hold never filled with treasure so vast.

Black Market

Light the fire, fan the flames, and rake me through the coals
then take me to the market where the artists sell their souls.
Each and every frame is plated and the canvas hides the cost,
so they can hang you in the gallery to display what is lost.

Nine winters at the easel and the mailbox never sings,
just a stack of polite passings official letters bring.
The appraisals have learned my name and the sculpture's gotten proud.
The syllables echo through your chapel even if they're not spoken
aloud.

I watch the coronated smiling from their covers on the stand,
every brushstroke taking orders, every anthem made as planned.
A whisper starts its journey through the very marrow of my spine:
"Paint the water how the market wants, who cares about the wine?"

Maybe hunger is a compass that's been pointing at the fault,
perhaps genius is in obedience to its pension in the vault.
Lose trust that all my burning mattered like a candle to the sun
for if art is what the buyer says, then mine was never one.

No. The fire wasn't lit for them and hunger will never be proof
a cathedral's still a cathedral with a hole punched in the roof.
Let the market crown its own reflection and all the copied carbon stay
gold:
I would rather starve as bottled lightning than be fattened, framed, and
sold.

The Meta-Sin

We choose the haze where clarity once burned,
a deliberate dimming of the inner light,
and turn from mirrors that would have returned
the unflinching gaze we forfeit to the night.

Not lust that pulls, nor blindness born of chance,
but calculated drift from what we are;
we abdicate the throne of self at a glance,
and crown distraction sovereign where truths once stood ajar.

The mind, alert, elects its own eclipse,
aware yet willing, seals the deeper door;
it walks the surface, tasting shallow sips,
while depths lie waiting, patient, on the floor.

This is the sin no scripture needs to name:
to know the self and still refuse the claim,
to wake each morning and forget the flame.

Rabid Obedience

They heel at the faintest tremor of the bell,
tails thrashing like metronomes gone wild,
eyes glazed with the fever of a spell
that binds the pack in one obedient child.

The voice arrives, a shadow without face,
a murmur threaded through the evening air,
and every throat inclines in perfect grace,
as if the word were breath they need to share.

Once, perhaps, a question stirred the blood,
a flicker of the why beneath the how,
but time has smoothed it to a quiet flood
of yes, and yes again, and yes right now.

See how they circle, noses to the ground,
sniffing the scent of orders yet to come,
their fangs polished bright, yet never sound
unless the unseen hand decides the drum.

The chain is silk, invisible and fine,
it kisses skin until the skin forgets
the weight was ever anything but mine,
a second spine we wear without regrets.

And when the moon drags madness to the full,
they bay in chorus, voices sharp and clear,
not knowing hunger drives the frantic pull,
only that harmony is safest here.

Yet in the hush between the given cues,
a single ear might twitch against the grain,
a pause too brief for masters to accuse,
a tremor in the rhythm of the chain.

It lingers, that small fracture in the night,
no trumpet call, no banner raised on high,
just space enough to taste the coming light
where no one kneels, and no one needs to lie.

The collar lies unclasped upon the floor,
unnoticed, unremarked, and nothing more.

Turnstile

Everyone fumbles for the same small key,
the one they swear will turn at last
and open some door to an office
where the air is cool and losses stay past.

They crowd the hallway, shoulders touching,
each convinced the lock is personal,
that behind the brass plate their name waits
already carved, already merciful.

I keep my hands in empty pockets.
No key, no map, no polished floor.
What I want is not another threshold
but the shaft itself, the long drop through the core.

Let the cable hum and the dark rise up,
let the walls fall away in perfect silence,
some elevator plunging past the numbered lights,
some mine shaft opening its patient violence.

Down there the ore is older than regret,
the vein runs steady, unconcerned with gain.
Whatever it holds, it holds without promise,
without the need to be named.

I step into the cage and close the gate.
The others stay, still searching for the fit.
The floor beneath me gives, the darkness greets me
like a hand that never quite forgets.

Plain Sight Prince

A shadowy court speaks whispers that bind
The golden throne to fate's design,
A figure walks the common line,
Unmarked by crown or jeweled rind.

He treads the dust of market squares,
Where merchants hawk their daily wares,
And beggars lift their hollow stares,
Yet none discern the blood he bears.

His voice, a murmur soft and plain,
Carries the weight of ancient strain,
A lineage lost in time's refrain,
Concealed within the mundane vein.

Through festivals and famine's grip,
He watches empires slowly slip,
His wisdom forged in quiet trip
Of years that carve but never strip.

No fanfare calls his hidden name,
No banners blaze his silent claim,
He rules in absence, free from fame,
A sovereign soul in borrowed frame.

And when the stars align to show
The truth that only shadows know,
He fades into the afterglow,
Leaving the world to wonder slow.

Ikarious

No one teaches compassion like the devil...
just hear me out before you close the book.
He finds you at your most disheveled,
knows every crooked corner, every nook,
and brings you down to exactly his level.

There isn't a lecture, nor does he suggest.
He simply shows you the door with the broken latch
and watches while you do the rest,
while heaven's hands stay clean without a scratch;
the devil alone will see you fail his test.

But when you've crawled back out of what he gave,
when you've worn the face you swore you'd never wear,
you stop throwing stones from the mortal grave.
As if suddenly you recognize the hunger beneath the stare,
and instantly know exactly what it was he came to take.

The priest can preach it. The saint can teach it clean.
But compassion born from comfort is a pleasant lie;
some lesson mouthed but never really seen.
The devil makes you live the reason why,
makes sure you know each stop on what it means.

He is no more good than this is a sermon.
But grace that's never suffered has a hollow ring.
The ones he's touched walk different from the joint
of knowing and the weight that knowing brings...
they love like people burned, and that's the point.

Abraxis

There are things buried beneath the pews filled by nuns,
rooster-headed, serpent-legged, whip raised at the sun,
three hundred sixty-five emanations in one name,
the year itself wearing armor unclaimed.

I found you the way most people find you now,
in a footnote, flanked by danger and vows,
a god the councils voted out of the pride
for the crime of refusing to pick a side.

Light and dark report to the same office in you.
The dove and the hawk draw the same paycheck, too.
Every priest I ever met wanted me to choose,
and every year I lived brought me more of the news.

The rooster crows at the coming dawn,
The serpents remember where we have been.
The whip is for the horses and the fawn,
which is to say, for time, which is to say,
for the only thing that ever actually threatened me.

If you are real, you already know our name.
Both columns. Every entry, stained.
And if you are only a picture on a stone,
then the stone still says what I came here to say:

that a man is not the war between his halves.
He is the treaty.
Signed daily.
Ratified in the dark.

Duart

The hills rose hard where e'er stood,
Their feet set firm in stone and rain;
The land took oath in flesh and blood
And learned the weight of clan Maclean.

From Gillean's hand the axe was sworn,
To cut a path through mist and fear;
Not forged for praise, nor raised in scorn,
But held when all that's loved is near.

Hector strode where tides ran red,
His name a line the storm would test;
He fought for more than quickened dead,
He fought so loss might still have rest.

The loch keeps truths the tongue lets go,
The wind repeats what bones retain:
What's taken still moves deep below
Duart, the heart of the clan Maclean.